

The misuse value of the TV set

Reading media objects in transnational urban spaces

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ABSTRACT ● This article uses photography to document what I call 'television settings': the video installations that people make in everyday life by putting objects and images on and around the TV screen. Its focus is not on domestic TV, but rather on treatments of the TV set outside the home, in urban spaces of work and leisure that serve, and are operated by, members of immigrant communities in the USA. These treatments of the screen combine raw materials of diverse origin to register the complexities of transnational experience. Studies of transnationalism often describe media images as links to the elsewhere of the lost homeland. But TV settings complicate such singular views of TV's relationship to place, calling attention instead to uses of the screen as an object in the 'here and now'. Intertwining transnational perspectives on locality with the protocols and contingencies of small-scale commerce in the USA, the TV settings examined in this article testify to the flexibility of TV as an object through which people mark their positions in transnational and local cultural networks simultaneously. ●

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Viewing is not the only everyday use of television that routinely involves creativity, unpredictability, problem-solving, indeterminacy and expressiveness.

A vast repertoire of ideas and gestures comes to life in the placement of the screen in a particular environment, in the things that decorate it and in the images it sits near in social space. In John Hartley's words, 'Each TV programme may be the same for all the millions of its viewers, but what's "on TV" – literally on it – is never the same; it's always personal, private and significant' (Hartley, 1992: 110). Among the diverse significations Hartley and others have identified in the everyday codes of the TV set are links between the screen and the shrine (Lyons, 1990; Boym, 1994: 151; Gillespie, 1995), uses of the console as a site for displaying artifacts of social mobility (Leal, 1990; Morley, 1992: 214) and treatments of TV as a center of domestic celebration, a place where birthday cards and Christmas presents are shown off (Hartley, 1992: 109). Such uses of TV, documented from a variety of perspectives, call attention to a host of expressive practices centered around the TV *console*, and not just the image on the screen (Fiske, 1990). Ondina Fachel Leal puts it well: '[T]he place of the TV and the place of all decorative objects are not arbitrary. They confer upon each other, as parts of a system, relational properties and significance' (Leal, 1990: 21).

This article traces some characteristic properties of the video installations that people make in everyday life. Using photography to document what I call 'TV settings', I analyze these treatment of the screen as evidence of a circuit of social practice and creative labor, and I explore the ideas about media, and related objects, that they embody. My focus is not the domestic TV set, but rather treatments of the console outside the home. Specifically, I am concerned with TV settings produced in urban spaces of work and leisure in the USA, in service establishments – food stores, snack bars, video stores and so on. Because many of these sites serve, and are operated by, members of immigrant communities, this analysis pays close attention to the ways their TV settings express diasporic forms of culture. These treatments of the TV set often combine raw materials of diverse origin – from everyday ephemera, to religious icons, to family pictures – in creative arrays. Such combinations attest to the TV set's 'misuse value' for transnational peoples, 'misuse value' being a term that literary critic Bill Brown coins to describe 'an irregular if not unreasonable reobjectification of the object that dislodges it from the circuits through which it is what it typically is' (Brown, 1999: 3). TV settings, I will suggest, reassign use values to media objects in ways that register the complexities of *place* for transnational populations, and that shape the experience of local and long-distance communication just as much as TV images and the networks that deliver them. 'Place', as I mean it here, is not a bounded, preconstituted location, but rather, more dialectically, the particular way in which social relations on all spatial scales are rendered in everyday social space (Massey, 1994: 5). The positioning of the TV screen in a place, in relation to other images and things, signals the positions of people – workers, viewers, proprietors – in the dispersed



Figure 1 A typical TV setting, in which souvenir objects, sacred images and TV images create a sense of transnational space. *Photo: author's own.*

networks of transnational experience that define forms of modern urban community, both in pragmatic and symbolic terms.

All this happens through the visual juxtapositions and material combinations that define many TV settings as anonymously authored mixed-media statements, ones that foreground the screen's status as an object while simultaneously *animating* other objects, images and texts in relation to it. But they can be hard to notice in the flow of everyday experience in public places, however, so before cataloging this process of placing and positioning some kind of preliminary sketch of their assembly logics is necessary.

Figure 1 is a picture of a TV setting in a pizzeria called Bella Italia, located in a fairly densely populated suburb in the northeastern USA. Its TV set is not a characterless recent model in a matte black casing. Rather, it is an older console, in need of some service work, probably cast off when the owner upgraded to a newer, bigger, home screen. Here at Bella Italia, as in the other locations discussed later, the TV setting signals a particular cultural heritage. Obviously, in this particular case, it is Italy; the restaurant is decorated in the tricolor theme of the Italian flag, and the screen rests on a shelf that is painted green, white and red. Reading from left to right, the objects that appear around it, on the shelf and on the wall are:

- A trophy
- A satellite receiver
- An image of Patti LaBelle
- A bell

A clock

A ceramic plaque with a cartoon of a man holding a horseshoe and a red pepper
An actual horseshoe, pointing downwards, with a red pepper hanging between
its prongs

An image of Padre Pio

A souvenir plate from Italy

A surveillance camera

Two larger souvenir plates

Restaurant and liquor licenses

Smaller holy images of the pope and a monk

A bronze bust of a bull

Family photos, affixed to another municipal license.

Together, these diverse elements form what Grey Gundaker calls an 'object code' – a code that communicates through material things in particular arrangements (Gundaker, 1998). Let me explore these elements now in some detail, to introduce some of the logics of assembly that I will later address as *conventions* of the TV setting as an expressive form in transnational urban commercial space.

The concept of the 'object code' is useful because it expands awareness of signification beyond images and words, and allows us to see that the artifactual components of TV settings – regardless of their form and location and regardless of how 'accidental' they may seem – are utterances made with objects. Bella Italia's TV setting uses diverse signifying things, their variety bearing witness to the diversity of motives behind its construction. Some elements are forms of émigré cultural display – for example, the tricolor decorating motif and the sacred picture of Padre Pio, the Italian priest whose image here is much larger, and placed much higher, than that of the (Polish) pope. More minutely, the nostalgic yet touristic images of particular places on the plates, together with the red pepper (a folk symbol of virility and fortune), link this setting with Southern Italian culture, specifically Sicily. However, Italy is not the only thematic reference in this display. Other prominent elements have an entirely different significance. Some of the objects on and around the TV are clearly positioned here for pragmatic reasons. The surveillance camera, the TV, the trophy and the liquor license need to be in a high corner of the room, visually unobstructed and physically out of reach. But other object choices seem to derive from more inscrutable logics, such as the wordplay signaled in the juxtaposition of a photograph of Patti LaBelle and an actual bell, in a restaurant called Bella Italia.

This eclecticism bears witness to a heterogeneous set of human practices and motives, ranging from pragmatic, commonsense needs to more personal, national or religious cultural orientations. As statements made in mixed media, this TV setting (and others like it) is a trace of tactical acts,

poised between function and expression and designed to *do* things within its immediate space. Its production values originate, like those of cooking, homemaking and commuting, in what Michel de Certeau and colleagues have called 'a practical science of the singular' (de Certeau et al., 1998: 256). The result is a functionally and aesthetically hybrid sensibility that is not to be explained away but rather to be respected – not least because it prevents us from describing TV settings from the romantic perspective of the *flâneur*, speaking in what Meaghan Morris has called 'the boudoir talk of commodities' (Morris, 1998: 90).

But, more importantly, this hybrid aesthetic enables transnational TV settings like this one to augment a key televisual ideology: 'space-binding', the apparent collapse of distance wrought by telecommunication. (For different perspectives on this ideology of broadcasting, see, for example, Smulyan, 1994; Morley and Robins, 1995; Appadurai, 1996; Weber, 1996.) But they also complicate our sense of this ideology, because they show how it is activated through objects and signs as well as televisual images. A sense of telepresence emanates from the landscapes painted on the plates, captioned 'ricordo di Carini' ('a souvenir of Carini'), material elements of the TV setting which link the space of the restaurant to a place in southern Italy and enjoin a sense of spatial collapse. On Sunday afternoons, when the restaurant is crowded with soccer fans watching satellite broadcasts in Italian, the effect is particularly pronounced. Suddenly, the souvenir plates and the tricolor motif of the restaurant are integral to the images on screen. Together with TV images, advertisements for Italian products and Italian-language commentary, they make the restaurant seem like a total 'theme environment', a capsule of Italy in the USA.

Dean McCannell investigates how objects activate the space-binding effects of long-distance communication, noting that souvenirs and mementoes enact forms of 'elsewhereness' and transnational connection that are 'everywhere in the minutiae of our material culture' (McCannell, 1989: 148). The everydayness of elsewhere, he points out, is embodied in the fact that many souvenirs are utilitarian domestic objects that have become images – like the plates that hang in Bella Italia's TV setting. Although it would be an overstatement to call the TV set a high-tech cousin of the decorative plate and the souvenir tea towel, it does share with such objects an ability to blur the line between use value and symbolic value in the household economy (McCannell, 1989: 149). And like these hybrid objects, TV is a quintessential combination of image plane and utilitarian thing, both a picture to be viewed and a stand to be decorated with plastic flowers or a doily. In the end, however, McCannell's understanding of the space-binding powers of utilitarian and decorative objects offers limited insight into the use of souvenirs in TV settings. His comparison between souvenirs and TV cannot grant the latter any of the former's dialectical flexibility: 'If the individual does not bring home images of reality elsewhere, modern TV

programming will supply a bland, generalized stream of imagery' (McCannell, 1989: 152).

The Bella Italia TV setting suggests an alternative way of thinking about space-binding objects such as souvenirs and their relationship to TV. It foregrounds the fact that tourists are not the only modern subjects for whom commercial souvenirs have important meanings, and signals the availability of souvenirs for émigré appropriations. Indeed, the use of souvenir images in such contexts conveys the fragility of the distinction between tourist and immigrant – a fragility that is well understood in transnational communities, in which immigration often happens under the official stamp of the tourist visa (see Clifford, 1992; Kaplan, 1996: 62–3). There are important differences between the TV set and the souvenir as forms of transnational connection, but they do not stem from the opposition between genuine tourism and fake tourism that McCannell seems to propose. They reflect, rather, the different temporal frames in which representations of elsewhere can exist. On Sundays at Bella Italia, 'live', present-tense broadcasts contrast with the fixed, idealized, 'past-tense' images on the souvenir plates and the abstract and portable national symbolism of the flag motif. Against the collectivity of sport spectatorship, the vocal presence of the crowd and the distant-yet-present voices emanating from the screen, the souvenir becomes a more contemplative, individualized artifact – closer in affect to the holy image next to it than to the TV set. TV and the souvenir work together to produce a range of transnational connections. This sense of shifting and mobile changes in affect, produced in part by the changing images on the screen, itself reveals something crucial about the TV setting as a whole, something I will return to again at the end of this article: as multimedia displays, they are capable of involving very different modes of spatial experience and reproducing, in their conglomerate construction style, *multiple* textures of transnational experience rather than the singular form of virtual travel that emerges when we pay attention to the image alone.

If both the picture on the TV set and the picture on the souvenir plate can be seen as flexible, space-binding image/object combinations, then this also signals a further transformative quality of the TV setting as a convention of social space: not only do the objects around the screen take on televisual properties, they also shape perceptions of the TV console, making it seem more like an object itself. TV's contact with other objects emphasizes its status as a material thing and punctures inflated notions of its technological sorcery. This sense of ontological slippage, from thing to image back to thing again, is, John Caldwell points out, a property of TV imaging techniques: one of the key features of the visual effects that define contemporary TV style, he notes, is the 3-D computer animation technique that maps images on to things and transforms things into two-dimensional images. It is a spectacular effect that we barely notice in the flying logos, transparent scrims and moving word-objects that define TV aesthetics today (Caldwell,

1994: 142–7). A similar kind of transformative work emerges in the way that Bella Italia's TV set fails to eclipse the other images around it. This TV setting seems to *relativize* the medium's power in everyday life, by juxtaposing it with other meaningful things, such as the red pepper image or the picture of Padre Pio. In different ways, then, the routine combination of the TV screen with other objects, images and written texts alters the kind of thing that TV seems to be. The TV set in its TV setting thus serves as many things at once: an image among others, a three-dimensional stand on which to put things, an appliance and a flat surface on which signs are affixed.

Because they involve multiple and varied treatments of a single object, media installations like this one pose interesting questions for cultural studies research. Their spatial and material properties alert us to the possibility that 'televisual' spatial effects, of superimposing presence and absence, of interweaving near and far, are routinely achieved in the material cultural milieu that surrounds the image and the screen, with results less predetermined than the conquest of space that some theorists attribute to TV images alone (Meyrowitz, 1985; Weber, 1996). Indeed, TV settings caution against writing TV theory by isolating the specific properties of the medium in a mental laboratory. Instead, they raise the possibility that the medium's most overarching property is its *site-specificity* – a unique ability to combine with other media, and with local social logics, in particular places. For this reason, the camera is a useful, if not crucial tool in the study of TV's material culture. It preserves the singularity and, often, the illegibility of TV settings, documenting the positioning of the TV set as a very localized, personal response to particular practical and/or aesthetic contingencies in a particular environment. And it also registers the fact that, even when the TV set simply goes where there is room for it, it can act like a semiotic magnet, attracting diverse visual forms and objects (posters, calendars, handwritten signs, statuettes) to the space on or around it.

What follows, then, is an illustrated account of three groups of object, image and textual practices that could be termed 'conventions' of TV settings in small, urban retail locations: the placement of TV sets on top of fridges, the use of tourist images and commercial ephemera as decorative objects and the juxtaposition of the TV set with written signs. These may seem like mundane, unremarkable functional practices, but – like the Bella Italia TV setting – they are media conventions that enable transnational modes of 'space-binding' in different ways, and index the positioning of people in modern social space on several scales in the process.

A place on the fridge

The question of *where* to put the TV set in the small spaces of urban commerce is not a simple one. In fact, it introduces a shifting ambiguity that

may be discerned in many of the TV settings examined in what follows: the entangled need to meet both practical and aesthetic contingencies. This means that it is often difficult to reconstruct distinct motives out of the visible features of a particular TV installation. Consider, for example, the presentation of both TV and a sacred image in Figure 2, taken in a New York Indian restaurant popular with taxi drivers. The TV sits on top of the fridge, near a food poster and a picture of a Sikh saint (the picture is also a clock). The scene is hard to read because of the possibility of some very different interpretations. On the one hand, the antenna wire that connects the screen and the icon/clock joins the blessing gesture of the saint's hand to the Bollywood movies that play on the screen, suggesting a striking sense of continuity between the two image surfaces – parallel, perhaps, to the Hindi practices of 'devotional viewing' that Marie Gillespie traces in media use in a British Indian household (Gillespie, 1995). On the other hand, however, despite all the potential significations that this placement suggests, it seems clear that the screen and the sacred image are placed together for purely pragmatic reasons: both need to be plugged into electrical outlets. Indeed, it may be, in fact, that the saintly image hangs in this elevated position not out of reverence but rather because it is a convenient thing to wind the antenna wire around, or because someone wants to be able to see its clock face clearly.

Now, it might be tempting to seek a 'reading' of this TV setting that proclaims the primacy of one motive over the other – seeing the coincident placement of TV and the shrine in the same area of the room as *either* practical



Figure 2 The overhead placement of TV and shrine reflects both practical and symbolic concerns. Photo: author's own.

or symbolic. But I see this tension differently: not as an interpretive problem to be resolved but rather as an apt illustration of the fact that the practices involved in the production of TV settings can quite easily span the two logics. Indeed, TV settings bear witness to the impossibility of separating the axis of use value and the axis of symbolic value in everyday practices of objects (see Hoskins, 1998). It is we, the researchers, who want there to be a clear difference between the two kinds of meanings assigned to things; for the author of the TV settings, the distinction may be wholly spurious. Bella Italia again furnishes an instructive example. When, in a clumsily ethnographic fashion, I questioned one of the counterpeople about the meaning of some of the objects in the restaurant's TV setting, he laughed at the idea that some things (Padre Pio, the red pepper) might have a different meaning than others (the clock, the municipal license.) 'Oh, no,' he said: 'that's just where we put all our *stuff*.' Rather than seeing this response as mystification, I took it seriously as a reminder that things can be both mundanely practical and symbolically invested at the same time.

Instead of trying to disengage the practical and the symbolic in, say, the coincident placement of TV and the religious image in overhead space, we might be better off asking about the *compatibility* of the two kinds of motives. Both need to be located overhead in public social spaces, removed from the mundane world, beyond the reach of the casual passer-by, yet at the same time providing unobstructed visual access for all. Yet, the fact that they require comparable treatment does not mean that TV and the shrine are comparable affective objects, although they might in some contexts inspire equally devotional treatment (for an example, see Boym, 1994: 151). While the shrine belongs in the space above the everyday activities of the room out of reverence, TV is placed there because of the need to protect property and limit access. However, at times, as Figure 3 illustrates, space limits can force the proprietors of a space to make a choice about which artifact, the screen or the shrine, to place in the privileged overhead spot. Here, in a San Francisco Chinese restaurant, the shrine has displaced the TV from the perch specially built for it overhead; it sits instead on a counter, near the credit card verification device, near some antennae and plastic flowers, near a good luck cat and a laughing Buddha. To ask whether this choice was determined by a sense of the shrine as a more sacred object, or whether it reflects the fact that the screen and VCR together are too bulky for the shelf, is to make the mistaken assumption that *both* cannot be true, that in everyday practices of decoration, as in the cooking practices studied by Luce Giard, 'necessities and liberties overlap' (de Certeau et al., 1998: 201).

If contingency and availability combine with symbolic or aesthetic concerns to shape the construction of TV settings, then perhaps the best illustration of this combinatory logic is the conventional placement of TV sets on fridges. This is a characteristic treatment of the console, one that seems



Figure 3 The shrine here has displaced the TV set from its specially built overhead shelf. *Photo: Eric Weissman.*

to arise directly from the physical constraints of small commercial spaces in cities, although it is a practical decision that immediately opens up aesthetic concerns, as I shall presently explain. But first, from a pragmatic perspective, this placement of TV and fridge together reminds us that both are bulky yet essential elements of social space in small, informal locations where prepared food is sold – snack bars, delicatessens and ‘convenience’ stores. And, as Hartley points out in relation to domestic space, both the fridge and the TV set are ‘pivotal item[s] of capitalization’ (Hartley, 1999: 100). His proposal that we view the fridge as an unheralded predecessor of the TV set (1999: 100) certainly also applies to the space of the restaurant as well, where social arrangements are often structured by the placement of the two appliances. However, the parallel protocols of fridge and TV set placement unfold in site-specific ways, according to the social and architectural codes that define the home and the restaurant as places. In the latter case, the lack of spare space means that large cold cabinets, unlike domestic fridges, must often be placed outside the kitchen and in the dining area, in view of the customers.

This distinctive relocation of a utilitarian appliance, and its subsequent transformation as a stand for the TV, implicates both fridge and screen in aesthetic as well as practical problem-solving routines. As part of the public space of the restaurant, both fridge and TV must contribute to its atmosphere, and, sometimes, it seems as if the TV set has been put there to decorate, and disguise, the fridge. As Figure 4 illustrates, the visual result of such

positionings can be startling. Here at Sha Wer Ma King, a tiny New York restaurant, the TV screen sits on top of a glass-fronted refrigerator full of lettuces, next to a fan, amidst festoons of hanging artificial flowers, fruits and foliage. The (presumably unintentional) result is that watching TV here must also involve looking at the raw materials from which one's meal is assembled. Interestingly, though, Sha Wer Ma King's TV set is no longer there; a few months after I took this picture, the owner replaced the TV screen with a more contemplative object – a fish-tank. Now, the TV console sits high in a corner, on top of a taller cold food storage case. This substitution marks the fridge/TV combination as an aesthetic object, albeit an unsuccessful one.

The space of Sha Wer Ma King illustrates a second convention of the TV setting: the fact that particular *kinds* of images tend to recur in transnational, urban TV settings: plastic flowers, religious images, tourist posters and souvenir knick-knacks, food industry promotional images. These and other forms of commercial and cultural ephemera combine to form a cultural syntagm of the kind encountered earlier at Bella Italia, one that – as the next section suggests – involves a similar rearticulation of practical and aesthetic considerations.

Images around the TV

Figure 5 shows a fridge/TV setting in a New York pasta store, where visual clutter predominates. As in other sites, the TV's placement on the fridge is



Figure 4 TV is often placed on top of a refrigeration cabinet in small urban food and retailing settings. *Photo: author's own.*



Figure 5 The visual clutter of commercial and touristic ephemera is a characteristic feature of transnational TV settings in urban communities. *Photo: author's own.*

dictated by its status as a bulky object that needs some surface area, although the dense array of religious, personal, commercial and touristic images around it make the screen seem less like an object than a picture plane surrounded by other pictures. An advertising poster emblazoned with an olde worlde image of a lute covers over the blankness of the refrigerator door below the screen, making it seem as if someone was compelled to cover every available surface with images. Similarly, ephemeral image material referring to Italy crowds the rest of the room. Such cluttered mixtures of image sources and discourses are signature visual features of TV settings in small urban food stores, particularly sites identified with a national cuisine. As in *Bella Italia*, this TV setting fashions a cultural space from the visual remnants of publicity – in this case, regional tourist board posters, commercial calendars produced by food manufacturers and distributors and mass-produced religious images ‘customized’ with the addition of a printed caption promoting a particular church.

It might be tempting to view the deliberateness of this aesthetic saturation as evidence of a clearly defined break between the symbolic and the practical, the choice of visual decorations for the store inhabiting an entirely different realm of decision making than the choice of the fridge as a stand for the TV. But this image material is likely to have come to the store as giveaways packed in the same box as a shipment of merchandise or raw ingredients, a provenance that suggests that this mixed aesthetic of commercial ephemera is also the product of convenience and availability. Such

conventional images are seasonal forms, circulating ritually as promotional communication between suppliers and small businesses. They are presented to the store as decorations and as a form of free advertising for the manufacturer. If the conventional placement of TV sets on fridges is an act of making do based on demands of visibility and availability, so, too, then, is the choice of these decorative images.

Figure 6, an elaborate TV setting formed out of commercial images in a Russian delicatessen in San Francisco, illustrates how TV images and food images work together in TV settings to conjure what Luce Giard terms the intangible sense of *terroir*: 'the tang of the soil', the reminder of home activated by the taste buds (de Certeau et al., 1998: 184). This TV/VCR combination perched on top of the fridge is surrounded by a large number of visual decorations, most of them promotional give-aways – commercial magnets, stickers, postcards, posters and so on. The overall effect is striking. Pink, glossal images of smoked fish and caviar reach out to the screen from their posters. Their briny cuisine images combine with the dated images of Russian variety shows on screen (home-videotaped from a satellite broadcast) to render a festive Slavic atmosphere in multiple sensory dimensions. With its posters and its TV shows, the store provides a free émigré media display for waiting customers on a Saturday morning.

Again, like the placement of the screen on the fridge, the arrangement of these small commercial trivia meets aesthetic and functional criteria simultaneously. The magnets both hold the poster to the fridge and, perfectly spaced and regularly interspersed, create a distinct visual pattern at the same time. The sense of deliberateness in this arrangement is perhaps most strongly conveyed by the placement of the big, singular, brand name F of the Fila sticker. The symbol is clearly anomalous, having little to do with food. The fact that it is here at all suggests that perhaps someone found its bold brand image too appealing to pass up, but in affixing it felt compelled to mark its distinctive visual qualities, and consumer reference, by segregating it from the other stickers and magnets. Or, perhaps, its meanings remain personal to the author; as Gundaker's study of object codes and paraliterate inscriptions in African America illustrates, sometimes all the observer can do is identify traces of deliberation in the construction of signifiers that are otherwise not recognizable. Either way, in glaring out of the photograph, this Fila sticker reminds us once more that such aesthetic assemblages are not defined by their cultural 'purity', but rather by the fact that they are, unproblematically, admixtures of connotations and statements, of practical and aesthetic purposes.

As a TV setting, this commercially constituted Slavic display rewards closer scrutiny because it focuses attention on a logic of assembly that is utterly characteristic of TV settings. As in the Bella Italia TV setting discussed earlier, each of the elements in the combination has transformative and montage-like properties. The elements seem to shift one another's status



Figure 6 Videotapes of Russian satellite TV combine with posters and fridge magnets to create a sense of Slavic culture in this delicatessen. *Photo: Eric Weissman.*

as object, image and text – the magnets are things as well as image surfaces, the fridge and the TV set are both image surfaces and things that often get put together. But this logic is highly televisual, and not simply because it mixes images, objects and pictures in a hodgepodge, hybrid aesthetic. It also – like network TV's endless recycling, or 'repurposing', of footage (such as out-takes) – obeys a logic of construction and display in which *nothing goes to waste*. The great care taken by the anonymous author(s) of this multi-media production, arranging the magnets and stickers on the fridge and the postcards on the mirror so precisely, suggests that as more ephemera arrive on the scene, they will likely be added to the display (and probably occasion further adjustments in the entire visual system too).

It may seem frivolous to spend so much time talking about stickers and fridge magnets, elements of contemporary visual culture that are microbial in their ubiquity and, to casual eyes, their invisibility. But I see them as absolutely crucial for understanding the TV setting as a kind of media production. Not only are stickers a pervasive form of everyday decoration (and, for children, ritual exchange), but any attempt to describe the visual and occupational atmosphere of the retail workplace would be incomplete without a consideration of the labor such ephemera perform. Ephemeral does not mean inconsequential; as José Muñoz notes, the concept of ephemera, 'far from filtering materiality out of cultural studies, reformulates and expands our understanding of materiality. Ephemera . . . [are] linked to alternative modes of textuality and narrativity like memory and performance' (Muñoz, 1996: 10). I would add that the importance of ephemera as alternate modes of daily life is, perhaps, common knowledge for anyone who has ever worked in retail, where one of the few fun parts of the job – certainly more fun than operating the cash register – is being asked to make a sign, or put up some decorations, or arrange a display.

But more crucially, such ephemera are important because they point to an oversight in mainstream scholarly approaches to capitalist visual culture. Most of the time, we concentrate on the visibility of commercial space in its most standardized forms, focusing on the mall or the department store or some other spectacular site of point-of-purchase decoration. As Daniel Miller suggests in *Capitalism: An Ethnographic Approach*, we rarely examine 'non-spectacular shopping' or the small commercial world of the shopkeeper, even though it is the material culture of such everyday sites that best illustrates the 'marked difference between "pure capitalism," which comes directly from economists' models, and the kind of organic capitalism that describes the day-to-day practice of commerce' (Miller, 1997: 9, see also 248–67). Of course, as Meaghan Morris has pointed out, standardized commercial culture isn't really standardized at all, except in the eyes of the snooty cultural critic (Morris, 1998: 67). However, to look *only* at chain store aesthetics and their channels of appropriation by consumers is to

ignore the commercial aesthetics of more micro-level sites of capitalist visual culture, such as the small retail store.

When you actually start to pay some attention to the display strategies of the small retail workspace, then the first thing that becomes apparent in such places is their difference from the visual techniques of the chain store's visual merchandising department. The posters, calendars, religious images and personal photographs that comprise the small urban business's decorative repertoire are deployed in ways that have little in common with the conventional retail logics of branding and traffic direction. Nor, by extension, do their TV settings share much with the commodity-based object codes of demonstration videos at the point of purchase. In the small retail store, the TV's implied spectator is more likely to be the worker, not the customer (as in the pasta store of Figure 5, where I had to lean over and snap this picture of the TV set behind the counter).

On this small-scale retail level, TV settings also tell us more than just a commercial narrative. They also express individual and collective biographies of international movement, as artifactual traces of the various dimensions of transnational experience that immigrant business styles register. In this delicatessen (Figure 6), the TV image and the ephemera surrounding it link émigré retail space in a US city both to the elsewhere of Russia and to the here and now of the USA. The variety show on the video screen, along with the tapes scattered beside the screen on top of the fridge, create a sense of Russia as a space of media production and of locally changing cultural fashion with which émigré shoppers and workers may wish to remain *au courant*. But the images of smoked fish conjure a different relation to homeland again; produced by a Russian wholesale company, they reference a timeless and more nostalgic sense of place as cuisine. And these two ways of making 'Russia' present are yet again offset by the fridge magnets and stickers. Arranged for display with such care and attention, they remind us that advertising ephemera, ubiquitous elements of US capitalist culture, have only recently started to be produced in Russia and eastern Europe. As fetishized US ephemera, they too might reflect the life experience of transnationality, along with the posters and the TV image. Perhaps the author of this TV setting experienced the powerful attraction to the ephemera of US popular culture – logos, disposable containers of brand-name goods, plastic shopping bags – that Svetlana Boym observed in 1970s Soviet culture (Boym, 1994: 65). (This careful display of stickers and magnets certainly resonates with transnational experience – as teenage emigrants to the USA from the UK, my sister and I were obsessed with the fact that so many different kinds of stickers were available for personalizing and decorating our stuff.) Ephemera, then, mark out an arena of everyday practice in the TV settings that might be worth examining in detail for the ways they bear witness to complex spatial movements and crossings.

Animating images and things in transnational statements, such uses of the

TV set mark out different places for people to occupy in local and national or international social contexts. Their implications for geographical media theory are explored more fully in the following, final, section. This section concerns a third convention of the TV setting: the frequent affixing of textual material, such as signs to the spectator, directly to the TV set itself. In conjunction with the screen image, these words position people both in space and in forms of discourse, from consumerism to cosmopolitanism. Like the poster, the souvenir or the sticker, they help to link the TV settings to spatial networks and social words that are wider than the space around the screen.

Glued to the TV set

Things are often stuck to the TV set in public TV settings – literally glued to the screen. This practice emphasizes that the TV set, as distinct from the TV image, is a flexible and multifaceted mode of local communication in social space. Frequently, this communication consists of announcements, instructions, promotions and other forms of institutional speech. Such signs are often highly reflexive, concerning the use of the TV set itself. A typical example may be seen in Figure 7 – a TV screen in a delicatessen on the far west side of lower Manhattan. The establishment serves taxi drivers, office

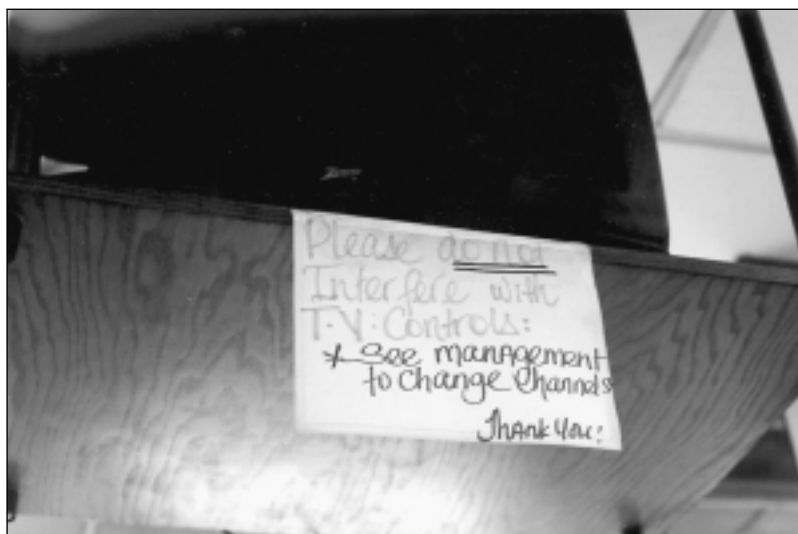


Figure 7 Like TV programs and ads, signs attached to TV sets often use direct address. *Photo: author's own.*

workers and sundry other west-siders in search of some fast food and perhaps a bottle of beer. It is rarely crowded, although people do seem to congregate there to watch sports and news on the three large screens. The TV setting is minimal; the screen is not clustered with other objects, but is separated from the space by its overhead position. But it is nevertheless distinctive because of the large sign, penned in three different colors, that hangs from the panel below the screen. Its message is an address to the spectator one frequently encounters in public – a warning not to touch. The other TV screens in the space have also been annotated in this way; their identical signs, elaborately inked in three colors, reflect the care with which one makes signs in retail jobs.

Signs to the public like this, so common in urban space that we don't think twice about them, are interesting in relation to conventional ideas about the way TV hails its viewer. Direct address, speaking to the viewer in the second person, is often seen as central to TV images and programming flows. Such signs, authored by 'the management', suggest that direct address is a discursive property of the TV set as well. It is not just the image, but also the console, it seems, that is (so the argument goes) 'forever buttonholing, addressing its viewer as if holding a conversation with them' (Ellis, 1992: 132). But if this way of talking directly to the spectator is not just a seductive ruse of the apparatus but also a tangible form of local communication,



Figure 8 Signs in English and Chinese, stuck to a TV set showing a Hong Kong movie, form a point-of-purchase display that says different things to different consumers. *Photo: author's own.*

perhaps the effects of this discursivity are less monovocal or predictable than some critics make them out to be. The signs and stickers that often end up glued to the TV set, in short, potentially diversify the meaning of direct address as a form of TV speech, and attest to TV's availability as a tool for shaping local social and discursive space.

The potential flexibility of direct address to the viewer, even as a form of commercial speech, is especially apparent in small urban establishments serving transnational communities. In such contexts it can signal, in material ways, the complex interrelationships between physical location and affective localities in daily life. A rather unique example of this is the striking use of textual signs shown in Figure 8. The image is of a TV set perched on a ledge outside a Chinese-language video store in New York's Chinatown. The basement store is difficult for passers-by to notice, so the screen serves as a prosthetic store window, promoting the latest merchandise in the open air (in this case a film featuring martial arts star Jet-Li). A bilingual sign attached to the top of the screen advertises in English 'buy three, get one free'. The Chinese lettering beside it says the same thing, although it adds that the sale celebrates a particular Taiwanese festival.¹ The signs on the side and the bottom of the screen are not translated into English. The vertical sign on the left invites customers to apply for discounted senior bus passes in the video store, and the sign on the bottom offers an even more attractive discount on tape purchases than the one advertised in the bilingual sign above: 'pay \$100 for 100 tapes'.

As point-of-purchase TV, this TV setting produces a complex sense of cultural space not only in the way it addresses different subjects in English and Chinese respectively, but also in the juxtaposition of on-screen image and text. Media images are often described as key components of the cultural space that Mayfair Mei-hui Yang calls 'transnational China' – 'the spatial and geographical extension of Chinese culture across national and political boundaries . . . becoming more connected and integrated through the reception of an increasingly common body of cultural products by dispersed Chinese audiences and readers' (Yang, 1999: 7–8). But, in contrast to this sense of media as transcending geography, the Chinese language *signs* in this TV setting acknowledge the more localized conditions of urban immigrant life. The vertical sign speaks to the difficulties of navigating issues such as housing and transportation in a world in which one is considered a stranger. The other hails a spectator who is a habitual viewer of Chinese language media, and who has enough available cash to buy tapes in bulk. If the *image* binds space by making 'elsewhere' present, then the *texts* that surround it are reminders of the historical location of the subject in the here and now. And, moreover, in their selective bilingualism, these signs also register the transnational conditions of life in a large immigrant community that is also a tourist destination – like New York's Chinatown. This layering of spatial reconfigurations through the media image and the media object confirms the

site-specific dimensions of the TV set, as part of the built environment and a particular cultural milieu.

In bringing together the imaginary, the bureaucratic and the economic dimensions of immigrant subjectivity all at once, this TV setting also returns us to the intertwined sense of the aesthetic and the practical discussed in the previous two sections. After all, transnational *experience* surely spans both realms, in this case from the affective aesthetics of transnational China to the local pragmatics of getting around New York. This TV setting seamlessly incorporates both practical and aesthetic dimensions of transnationalism in one material assemblage. Its components thus index the material conditions of being a person from elsewhere, and underscore the multiple forms of space-binding and belonging that TV settings achieve, aligning objects, words and images in one syntagm. Like the Russian delicatessen's TV setting, patterned by stickers and posters, the visual nexus formed by this screen and surrounding texts recognizes different aspects of transnational experience as everyday cultural knowledge, reminding us how routinely the near and the far are articulated together in the use of media artifacts.

By itself, the observation that objects perform this act of transnational connection is not particularly new; in addition to McCannell's examination, there are the evocative inventories of diasporic artifacts that constitute a set piece of transnational studies (see, for example, Appadurai, 1996: 4). But such studies often assume that the spatial operations of media objects are confined to the spectacularity of long-distance space-binding, of magically making the distant near. What I think we can learn from the mixture of the spectacular and the banal, of 'transnational China' and New York transit passes, in this one treatment of the TV set is the possibility that media objects bind people to local space as well. This TV setting, and the others examined here, serve as reminders that transnationalism's mobilization of objects, images and words to form spatial connections also involves forging connections to the world in which one arrives. (On the use of TV sets for this purpose, see Conquergood, 1986: 1.) As transnational multimedia, commercial TV settings like the ones I have examined here similarly ground their author and spectators in the material present even as they connect them to the 'there and then'.

Conclusion

Looking at TV settings closely, as I have in this article, conveys the importance of the *physical goods* through which transnational media images travel; as a critical activity, it inserts media images into 'the social life of things' (Appadurai, 1996; Morley, 1992: 213, 236). TV sets, like videotapes, audio cassettes, cell phones and computer disks, can be seen as

transformative objects, highly invested with what Brown (1999) calls 'misuse value':

By misuse value I mean to name the aspects of an object – sensuous, aesthetic, semiotic – that become legible, audible, palpable when the object is experienced in whatever time it takes (in whatever time it is) for an object to become another. (Brown, 1999: 2)

Although it sounds like a romance of the commodity, the concept of misuse value is a useful label for the resourceful use of a TV set and a video image to advertise both videotapes and bus passes. 'Misuse value' or, as Brown (1998) calls it in another context, 'rehabilitative reification' certainly describes the practical aesthetics involved in the construction of TV settings – the placement of the screen on the fridge, and the use of commercial ephemera to make the resulting assemblage into an aesthetic object. And 'misuse value' might also apply to other circuits of tactical production that define transnational media practices – like the everyday labor of home-taping satellite broadcasts for screening in a shop. Such practices, like the 'flexible citizenship' Aihwa Ong discerns in the international movements of Chinese businessmen and merchants, are 'expressions of a habitus that is fully tuned to the turbulence of late capitalism' (Ong, 1998: 157). As I have tried to show, the multilayered spatial object that is the TV set in its TV setting registers this turbulence in the social space of everyday urban places.

To grasp in full the material textures of transnational experience that TV settings and other media objects produce in such contexts, further exploration is surely necessary. A more sustained form of engagement than mine might draw more extensively on the poetic and participatory research capabilities of ethnography or oral history. (See Hartley, 1992: 100–16 for one template of this method.) Closer analysis of TV settings will no doubt help us see how other forms of difference than national difference – gender, for example, or urban/rural identity – also shape the construction of TV settings. Perhaps, like gifts, media objects with high misuse values mark out relations of gender in the way they circulate and are exchanged (Strathern, 1988). I hope, indeed, that further study of TV settings will flesh out the relatively skeletal forms of signification and power sketched here.

But the possibility of different conclusions only underscores a final benefit of further study of media's material culture. Few cultural objects are as routinely reduced to a singular spatial 'effect' as TV is in the scholarly imagination; as the title of one book polemically puts it, TV endows contemporary culture with 'no sense of place' (Meyrowitz, 1985). Even when this conquest of space is valorized, as in studies of diasporic media use (Appadurai, 1996; Yang, 1997), a similarly singular sense of media, as forms of travel *away from* one's material, historical present, emerges as the master trope for decoding televisual geographies. But, as I have tried to show, there is more to TV and video than their images and stories; the image is often connected

to other images and objects in the space around the screen, together rendering the material, historical traces of wider spaces and processes. Examining them opens up pathways for more complicated theorizing of spatiality and artifactuality in TV. They enlarge our sense of the medium's material form in social space, a form that includes a movement between forms of thingness and forms of image, as well as between places and scales. Their complexity suggests that, when 'fretting fruitlessly about the effect of TV on people's behaviour, morals, or politico-aesthetic sensibilities' (Hartley, 1992: 98), or obsessing about how TV's functions as a technology for communicating over distances destroys places, we might do well to marvel at the semiotic flexibility of the TV set as a thing that people use to say things to each other *locally* – especially when the topic of this local communication is another place.

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- 1 I must note that the sign on top of this TV set changes quite regularly. Here, its lettering is ambiguous: the festival it names translates as 'parents festival' but no such festival exists. However the spoken word for parent sounds a lot like the name of the festival honoring the founding of the republic of Taiwan. I am indebted to Zhang Zhen for her translation of these signs.

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